

music' was adopted to emphasise RIFF's distance from the genres it doesn't programme, namely contemporary iterations of rock, pop, Bollywood and electronic. Yet it's broad enough, says Bhatia, to "cover a large spectrum" of traditional sounds, from Indian classical to jazz and bluegrass as well as Celtic and tribal music from around the globe.

This year, the 16th edition of RIFF, held annually at the 15th-century Mehrangarh Fort around the night of Sharad Poornima when the moon is at its brightest in north India, will be staged from October 26 to 30. Unlike other festivals, there are no headliners, but several highlights.

For the 2023 instalment, these include multiple collaborations between Indian musicians. Jazz saxophonist Rhys Sebastian will team up with the Rajasthani folk trio SAZ for a set entitled 'The Cool Desert Project'. SAZ will also accompany kathak dancer Tarini Tripathi, who will perform to Rajasthani folk instruments instead of Hindustani classical beats. Percussionist Viveick Rajagopalan will helm 'Dholworks' in which Rajasthani and Maharashtrian dhol players will come together.

There will also be spotlights on wind instruments, which will be showcased in recitals by alghoza player Idu Khan Langa, Indian classical bansuri player Avadhoot Phadke and the Estonian 'improvisational' flute duo Kuula Hetke. The khartal, meanwhile, will be celebrated with a performance by veteran exponent Bundu Khan Langa and a 'battle' between Langa and Manganiyar purveyors.

The international contingent features percussionist Greg Sheehan and guitarist and singer Jeff Lang from Australia, violinist Jasser Haj Youssef from Tunisia, vocalist and multi-instrumentalist Miroca Paris from Cabo Verde, and the groups Ars Nova Napoli and Suonno d'Ajere from Italy. Sheehan, Paris and Sebastian will serve as this edition's 'rustlers' who will lead the RIFF Rustle, the closing ensemble jam.

> The term **'ROOTS MUSIC'** was adopted to emphasise RIFF's distance from the genres it doesn't programme—that is, contemporary iterations of rock, pop or Bollywood

The range and depth of the programme—Carnatic classical musicians, ghatam legend T.H. 'Vikku' Vinayakram and his son, singer Mahesh Vinayakram, are also on the bill—arguably makes Jodhpur RIFF India's closest equivalent to WOMAD or the World of Music, Arts and Dance, the long-running festival co-founded by Peter Gabriel. "We're not really in competition, but WOMAD [too] is more [about] the world of music rather than 'world music'. So, in that sense, we're similar," says Bhatia. ■

Amit Gurbaxani

THE FESTIVAL WILL BE RUNNING FROM SEPTEMBER 30 TO OCTOBER 22, PLAYING 100-MINUTE THEATRE SHOWS IN DELHI, CHENNAI, BENGALURU AND MUMBAI

festival running from September 30 to October 22 will play 100-minute theatre shows in Delhi, Chennai, Bengaluru and Mumbai. The line-up includes award-winning clowns from Canada, the US, Singapore, Germany and Italy, among other countries. "This is the first time we are travelling to four cities with a theatre show. ICF 2023 is our biggest edition yet—we have 30 shows that will reach an audience of 30,000 people. Our viewers range from three to 103," says D'Souza, who has been clowning for 33 years.

D'Souza, who goes by the clown name Flubber, pursued a course in clownology from the University of Lacrosse, Wisconsin, US in 2004. It is here he learned that every clown must build a distinct personality and name. "That's how I began to identify myself as Flubber, since I am tall with a rubbery body and a boisterous persona," he explains.

Apart from Flubber's performance at ICF 2023, audiences will be treated to RONE and Gigi from Japan, who are masters in pantomime, physical comedy and music. Another much-awaited showcase is by Sleepy the clown from Canada, who works with balloons. There's also Gaia Ma from Italy, who weaves tap dancing into her juggling act. "Each country brings its own flavour to clowning. For instance, the circus acts of unicycling and juggling are best performed by Germany or other European nations. Conversational comedy is the forte of Canada and India," says D'Souza.

While his current focus is the month-long festival, he will shortly begin prepping for carnivals and mall shows in December. "We'll be performing at multiple malls across Indian cities, including tier-2 ones. I'll also be conducting workshops for those who want to learn the nuances of clowning," he concludes. ■

Geetika Sachdev